



The ruins of Carthage, which was burned and ritually cursed after its capture in 146 BCE. A new Roman town was founded near the city around 48 BCE.

After the end of the Second Punic War, in 202 BCE, the Romans had allowed their ally King Massinissa of Numidia to encroach on Carthaginian territory. The peace conditions that ended the war forbade the Carthaginians to wage

“CARTHAGE MUST BE DESTROYED.”

Cato the Elder, Roman statesman

war without Roman approval. Unable to act, the Carthaginians were reduced to sending **embassies to Rome** to protest Massinissa's behavior. However, Rome sided with its ally, and one Carthaginian embassy in 162 BCE even resulted in Carthage being



Carthaginian tophet
A memorial stone from the tophet (cemetery) at Carthage, showing Tanit, the goddess of the heavens.

made to pay an annual fine of 500 talents. In 151 BCE, the Carthaginian government sent a military force to relieve a town that had been besieged by Massinissa, and the Romans reacted by **declaring war**. This was the **Third Punic War** (149–146 BCE). Rome's war was encouraged by the anti-Carthaginian senator **Cato**

the **Elder**, who made a series of speeches to the Senate calling for the destruction of Carthage. The first two years of the Third Punic war saw ineffective Roman attacks on towns around Carthage. In 147 BCE, a new commander was appointed, **Scipio Aemilianus**, who transformed Rome's fortunes in the war within a year.

In 167 BCE, the Seleucid ruler **Antiochus IV** outlawed Jewish religious practices in Judaea, leading to the **revolt of Judah Maccabee** and his brothers in 164 BCE. Judah Maccabee entered Jerusalem, reconsecrated the temple, and reestablished Judaism. The **Seleucid kingdom** then continued to decline (see also 280 BCE), with the overthrow of its ruler Demetrius I in 150 BCE by Alexander Balas rapidly leading to the **loss of the key satrapies** (provinces) of Media and Susiana.

“I SHUDDER TO THINK THAT ONE DAY SOMEONE MAY GIVE THE SAME ORDER FOR ROME.”

Scipio Aemilianus, Roman general and consul, on giving the order to burn Carthage, from Plutarch's *Apothegmata*

IN CHINA, RAIDS BY NOMADIC HSIUNG-NU TRIBES from 177 BCE gravely threatened the Han dynasty's northern borders. In 139 BCE the imperial envoy, Zhang Qian, set out to Central Asia to seek out **possible allies** against the Hsiung-nu. His epic journey helped scout the way for Chinese expansion as far as Dunhuang, and the foundation of a number of **new Central Asian commanderies** by 104 BCE. Zhang Qian was held captive by the Hsiung-nu for some years during his journey before he was able to make an escape. Under emperor Wu (141–87 BCE) the Chinese launched **several offensives** against the **Hsiung-nu**, particularly in 121 BCE and 119 BCE, after which the frontier was quiet for almost 20 years.

In the Near East, the shrunken and near-helpless **Seleucid realm** (see 170 BCE) was riven by civil wars and prey to interference from the Parthians, the Hasmonaeans, and, increasingly, the Romans. In 142 BCE, the Maccabees succeeded in wresting Jerusalem from Seleucid control and established a **Hasmonaean kingdom**, with Jerusalem as its

capital, under which a Jewish dynasty ruled until Jerusalem was captured by the Romans in 63 BCE.

On the **Iberian Peninsula**, the Romans had conquered most of southern Spain and parts of Portugal (where the Lusitanians vigorously resisted them) by 174 BCE. A revolt by the Lusitanian leader Viriathus from 147 BCE was joined by several Celtiberian tribes in 144 BCE. This rebellion petered out after Viriathus was murdered in 140 BCE. In 133 BCE, Numantia, the main center of the revolt, finally fell to the Romans after a bitter siege. Its population was sold into slavery and Rome was left in control of all of Iberia, except the far north of Spain.

The **Third Punic War** came to an end when Scipio Aemilianus blocked Carthage's harbor then launched a **successful attack** on the city itself in spring 146 BCE. The last Carthaginian defenders died in an inferno in the city's main temple. The defeat of Carthage brought its 118-year struggle against Rome to an end. The Romans burned the whole city and deported its population to prevent any Carthaginian revival.



THE ROMAN REPUBLIC

After the overthrow of the last king in 507 BCE, Rome became a republic, ruled by two annually elected consuls. Over time the consuls came to be supported by other magistrates (praetors and quaestors), and tribunes of the plebs who had a special role in protecting the rights of the lower

orders. Later elections for the consulate became bitterly contested as the office provided great potential for enrichment and personal and family glory. After Augustus became emperor in 27 BCE the office of consul lost any real power, being increasingly awarded to imperial favourites.

